

Document 19: Grievance Redressal Committee Structure

Institution: Hyderabad Institute of Technology (HIT)

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1. Statutory Mandate and Jurisdictional Boundaries

In compliance with the regulations mandated by the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) and the University Grants Commission (UGC), the Hyderabad Institute of Technology (HIT) operates a formalized Grievance Redressal Mechanism. The institutional objective is to provide a secure, transparent, and time-bound platform for students to voice complaints regarding academic discrepancies, administrative inefficiencies, and infrastructural deficiencies.

It is critically important to understand the jurisdictional boundaries of the Grievance Redressal Committee (GRC). The GRC is authorized to handle complaints regarding unfair grading practices, withholding of original certificates, overcharging of tuition fees, discrimination by faculty, and severe infrastructural issues (e.g., non-functional laboratory equipment).

However, the GRC strictly does **not** possess the jurisdiction to investigate the following categories of complaints:

1. **Ragging and Hazing:** All such complaints are automatically routed to the Anti-Ragging Committee (ARC) as per Document 9.
2. **Sexual Harassment:** Any allegations of sexual misconduct must be directed exclusively to the Internal Complaints Committee (ICC), which operates under a completely separate national legal framework (POSH Act).
3. **Routine Grade Appeals:** Simple dissatisfaction with an exam score must go through the standard "Challenge Valuation" process outlined in the Examination Manual. The GRC will only intervene if the student possesses proof that the challenge valuation protocol itself was corrupted or bypassed.

2. The Digital Filing Protocol and Anonymity Rules

To ensure all complaints are timestamped and legally archived, the university has abolished paper-based grievance letters. All grievances must be filed exclusively through the "HIT e-Samadhan" digital grievance portal, which is accessible via the student dashboard.

When submitting a grievance, the student must authenticate their identity using their university LDAP credentials. The university does not accept anonymous grievances regarding academic or administrative matters. If a student fears retaliation from a specific faculty member, they can check the "Confidential Handling" box on the portal. This ensures that the student's name is heavily redacted and only visible to the Chief Nodal Officer, but the complaint itself remains legally tied to a verified student roll number.

Every successfully filed grievance generates a unique 12-digit alphanumeric Tracking ID. The portal provides real-time status updates, indicating whether the complaint is "Under Review," "Forwarded for Investigation," or "Resolved."

3. The Three-Tier Escalation Matrix

To prevent the central administration from being overwhelmed by minor localized disputes, the grievance redressal mechanism operates on a strict, sequential Three-Tier Escalation Matrix. A student cannot directly petition the University Chancellor; they must follow the chain of command.

Tier 1: Departmental Grievance Redressal Committee (DGRC)

- **Composition:** Chaired by the Head of the Department (HOD), consisting of two senior professors and one student representative from the final year.
- **Jurisdiction:** Localized issues such as timetable clashes, localized faculty behavior, internal lab equipment faults, and minor internal assessment disputes.
- **Resolution SLA (Service Level Agreement):** The DGRC is legally mandated to conduct a hearing and provide a written resolution on the digital portal within exactly 7 calendar days of the complaint being filed.

Tier 2: Institutional Grievance Redressal Committee (IGRC)

- **Composition:** Chaired by the Dean of Academic Affairs, consisting of the Chief Financial Officer, the Controller of Examinations, and the Chief Warden.
- **Jurisdiction:** If a student is unsatisfied with the Tier 1 resolution, they can escalate the ticket to Tier 2. The IGRC also directly handles high-level complaints regarding tuition fee overcharging, degree certificate withholding, and hostel mass-food-poisoning incidents.
- **Resolution SLA:** The IGRC must summon the involved parties and deliver a final administrative verdict within 14 calendar days of receiving the escalated ticket.

Tier 3: The University Ombudsman

- **Composition:** The Ombudsman is an independent, external authority appointed by the institutional Senate. The Ombudsman is always a retired District Judge or a retired Vice-Chancellor from a different public university. They hold no administrative ties or loyalties to the HIT management.

- **Jurisdiction:** The Ombudsman serves as the Supreme Appellate Authority. If a student feels the IGRC (Tier 2) has colluded against them or delivered an unjust verdict, they may file a final appeal to the Ombudsman.
- **Resolution SLA:** The Ombudsman operates on an independent schedule, but is mandated to resolve all appellate cases within 30 calendar days. The verdict delivered by the Ombudsman is absolutely final and legally binding on both the student and the university management.

4. Penalties for Frivolous and Malicious Complaints

The grievance portal is a powerful tool designed to protect student rights. Consequently, the weaponization of this tool to settle personal vendettas or harass faculty members is treated as a severe institutional offense.

If a complaint reaches the Tier 2 (IGRC) level and the subsequent investigation reveals that the student intentionally fabricated evidence, forged documents, or submitted a completely baseless allegation purely to defame a faculty member or peer, the committee will instantly dismiss the grievance and initiate punitive action against the complainant.

The penalty for filing a demonstrably malicious grievance is a fixed fine of ₹5,000, payable immediately. Furthermore, a permanent warning letter regarding "Administrative Perjury" will be filed in the student's academic dossier. If the false allegation caused severe reputational damage to a faculty member, the IGRC holds the authority to suspend the offending student for up to one full academic semester.

5. Group Grievances and Mass Petitions

The university recognizes that certain administrative failures—such as a sudden, unjustified hike in hostel mess fees, or a malfunctioning air-conditioning system across an entire computer laboratory during mid-terms—affect large cohorts of students simultaneously.

Students are permitted to file "Class-Action Grievances" through the e-Samadhan portal. To classify a complaint as a mass petition, a minimum of twenty verified students from the affected cohort must digitally co-sign the primary complaint using their individual student portal accounts within 48 hours of the initial filing.

Once a grievance surpasses the twenty-signature threshold, it completely bypasses the Tier 1 Departmental Committee and is escalated directly to the Tier 2 Institutional Grievance Redressal Committee (IGRC) as a "High-Priority Infrastructure/Policy Alert." The Dean of Academic Affairs is mandated to hold an open-town-hall-style hearing with the affected student cohort within five working days of the mass petition being validated.